

browser was their first product. In 1998, Netscape was bought by AOL. In the same year, it made its browser code open source, which formed the basis of the present Mozilla browser.

May: First Virus Writer Punished

In England, 26 year old Christopher Pile became the first person to be jailed for writing malicious code. Pile, besides spreading the Pathogen virus to virus makers on the Internet, also infected benign programs—including a virus checker!—that could be downloaded and run by unsuspecting users. Pile was sentenced to 18 months in jail.

1995: Java, DirectX, Dialup

May: Sun's JAVA Programming Language

Sun Microsystems introduced the Java programming language. The language that ultimately ended up being called Java in 1995 started off as “Oak” in 1991 for use in a TV set-top box. Creator James Gosling intended to create a platform-independent language that could be used in consumer electronics devices, specifically for the cable TV industry. While there were not many takers in the target market, the spread of the Internet in the 90s presented an unexpected opportunity. The capability of the language to be platform-independent proved to be a boon, since different platforms were being used to connect to the Internet. Java’s popularity exploded once Netscape, the most popular browser in the early years of the Internet, began supporting it. Applets—small programs written in Java—are presently seen liberally on sites in different forms, ranging from stock tickers to games.

A Java program requires the Java Runtime Environment to operate. While the program itself is the same, the Runtime varies with the platform—and this allows the same program to be run on all platforms, as long as the relevant Runtime environment is installed.